

THE HOUSE THAT REMEMBERED

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CHAPTER ONE

The House

Daniel remembered the house by its sounds.

The grandfather clock.

The kitchen pipes.

The third stair.

His grandmother's footsteps.

He hadn't been back in fifteen years.

Now, standing outside the front door, he wondered why he'd ever agreed to return.

The house looked smaller.

Everything did when you grew older.

He unlocked the door.

Dust filled the air.

"Hello?"

Nothing answered.

His grandmother was dead.

There was no reason to expect anyone to answer.

Still, the silence felt wrong.

Daniel walked into the hallway.

A photograph hung above the fireplace.

He remembered it.

His grandmother was young.

She was standing beside a man.

Daniel had never seen him before.

He reached for the photograph.

It fell from the wall.

The glass cracked.

Daniel turned it over.

Four words had been written across the back.

He never left this house.

Daniel frowned.

His grandmother had never mentioned the man.

Then the grandfather clock stopped.

12:00.

Daniel looked at his phone.

11:47.

The clock was fifteen minutes fast.

He laughed nervously.

"Old house."

He placed the photograph on the table.

Then he heard footsteps upstairs.

One.

Two.

Three.

Daniel froze.

The footsteps stopped.

He listened.

Nothing.

Then a fourth step.

Someone was walking toward the bedroom.

Daniel's bedroom.

He slowly climbed the stairs.

The hallway was dark.

At the end was his grandmother's bedroom.

The door was open.

He pushed it wider.

Empty.

He entered.

The room smelled of lavender.

Just as he remembered.

Then the door behind him closed.

Daniel turned.

The handle wouldn't move.

He pulled harder.

Nothing.

A whisper came from inside the wardrobe.

"Daniel."

He stepped backward.

The wardrobe door opened by itself.

Inside was a photograph.

A photograph of Daniel.

Standing in the same room.

Taken that morning.